01 / QUICK ID

Is it giant reed, common reed, or giant cutgrass?

Use this 3-way visual sort outdoors. The flower heads are clues; confirm with the leaf base or spikelet.

GIANT REED
Arundo donax

01



HABIT · Massive leafy, cane-like stand

LOOK FIRST

Broad, often drooping blades on robust jointed canes. Check for conspicuous **leaf-base lobes clasping the stem**.

INTRODUCED IN TEXAS

COMMON REED
Phragmites australis

02



HABIT · Tall wetland reed with a soft feathery plume

LOOK FIRST

Often a silky-looking, branched plume. Verify tiny **silky rachilla hairs** between florets.

LINEAGE NOT YET KNOWN

GIANT CUTGRASS
Zizaniopsis miliacea

03



HABIT · Tall coarse marsh grass with long arching leaves

LOOK FIRST

Coarse leaves with fine sawlike margins, a **very open branching panicle**, and a long papery inner ligule.

NATIVE IN BROADER REGION

FIELD PATH **Whole stand → Leaf base → Flowering head → Spikelet if needed**

Never ID from height or plume color alone.

02 / FIND THE STRUCTURE

The leaf collar is your best second clue

Follow one leaf blade down to its sheath. Expose the inside where they join — that is the ligule.

A ARUNDO

Broad, rounded leaf-base lobes



The actual Arundo blade base and pale fringed collar

Look: Prominent ear-like flanges wrapping around the culm.
Do not use hair presence by itself.

P PHRAGMITES

Short inner membrane with fine fibers



Actual Phragmites blade–sheath junction and hair fringe

Look: Fringed ligule; measure with a millimeter ruler.
Species identified ≠ lineage identified.

Z ZIZANIOPSIS

Long, papery true ligule



NOT THE LIGULE · Visible outside node and sheath; inner ligule NOT visible

Look for: Inner ligule **6–20 mm** long.
Our photograph does not expose it.

HOW TO EXAMINE A LEAF

1. **FOLLOW THE BLADE**
   Trace the flat green leaf toward the stem.
2. **OPEN THE SHEATH**
   Look INSIDE the blade–sheath junction; don't use a stem node.
3. **USE A RULER**
   Photograph the true ligule with a 1-mm scale.

03 / REPRODUCTIVE CHARACTERS

Heads first. Spikelets to confirm.

Compare real panicles, then examine mature spikelets under a 10× hand lens or magnification.



Arundo: branching head, often held relatively upright

ARUNDO

Large, stiffly branched plume; form varies.



Phragmites: many-branched, often silky plume

PHRAGMITES

Silky, feathery flowering head; form varies.



Zizaniopsis: conspicuously loose branching head

ZIZANIOPSIS

Large open panicle; male and female spikelets.

10×

THE RELIABLE ARUNDO–PHRAGMITES SPLIT

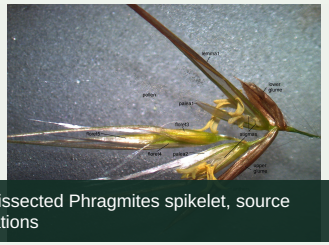
Where the silky hairs are attached matters more than how fluffy the entire plume looks.



Real Arundo spikelets; exact hair attachment not exposed

ARUNDO

Silk mainly on the **lower lemma** (floret bract). The **rachilla is hairless**.



Real dissected Phragmites spikelet, source annotations

PHRAGMITES

Long silky hairs on the **rachilla** between individual florets.

PHOTO HONESTY: The images above are real identified specimens but are not a perfect matching set of microscale hair-origin shots. Do not invent hairs or arrows on unseen structures.

04 / CONFIRM & DOCUMENT

Phragmites: species first, lineage second

Do not mark a reed stand invasive from a single flowering-head photo.

THREE TEXAS-RELEVANT LINEAGES



Source-labeled native American reed; NOT a Hays genetic voucher



Source-vouchered introduced reed collar; NOT a Hays voucher

CHECK	NATIVE *americanus*	INTRODUCED *australis*
Old sheath	Often sheds / peels away	Often remains attached
Exposed stem	Often glossy and reddish	Often duller and ridged
Ligule, approx.	1.0–1.7 mm	0.4–0.9 mm

Important: Gulf Coast *berlandieri* is another regional lineage. Even with a good photo, some stands remain **lineage unresolved**. Use multiple characters or genetic confirmation before treatment.

YOUR SIX FIELD PHOTOS

01 Entire colony and habitat

02 Full stem with attached leaves

03 Leaf base and older sheaths

04 Opened inner ligule + 1-mm scale

05 Attached flowering panicle

06 Ripe spikelets + scale (if present)

Bring: phone macro • 10× lens • ruler • notebook • gloves.

NO CONFIDENT ID? LABEL “REED-LIKE GRASS — REVIEW NEEDED”

SOURCES AND IMAGE CREDITS

Identification: USDA-NRCS Phragmites key; Minnesota AISRC; Arundo morphology; Kew Zizaniopsis.

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